

STEPCLIMBER · DESIGN PRECIS

StepClimber design precis

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
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Source	docs/02-concept.md @ uncommitted		

REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.7	2026-10-02	Amish Chadha	Figures from SCM-CAL-001 v0.5 (recalculated at 16 steps/min, 35 kg and the plus or minus 3 degree window; 4140 shaft with fatigue assessed; cost USD 788); concept media regenerated; appearance model brought to the constructable design
0.6	2026-10-02	Amish Chadha	Decisions of 2026-10-02 carried in (SCM-DEC-001 items 1 to 4, 6 and 7): 4140 cluster shaft, R5 35 kg and R3 16 steps/min for the first prototype, plus or minus 3 degree tilt window, first user group and pilot partner
0.5	2026-10-01	Amish Chadha	Constructable design (SCM-DDR-003); figures from SCM-CAL-001 v0.5; budget reported as a value-engineering target; media regenerated
0.4	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Recommendations accepted by Amish (DDR-002); 200 mm wheels, 150 mm arms, two-stage chain drive, plus or minus 6 degree tilt window; figures from SCM-CAL-001 v0.2; media regenerated

0.3	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Record Amish's 2026-09-25 decisions (SCM-DDR-001); replace estimates with SCM-CAL-001 figures; nosing clearance, handle force and landing corrections; media from the TRL 3 model
0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Populate to TRL 2 (architecture, cluster geometry, drive and energy numbers, tilt control, safety, media)
0.1	2026-09-24	Amish Chadha	Initial scaffold

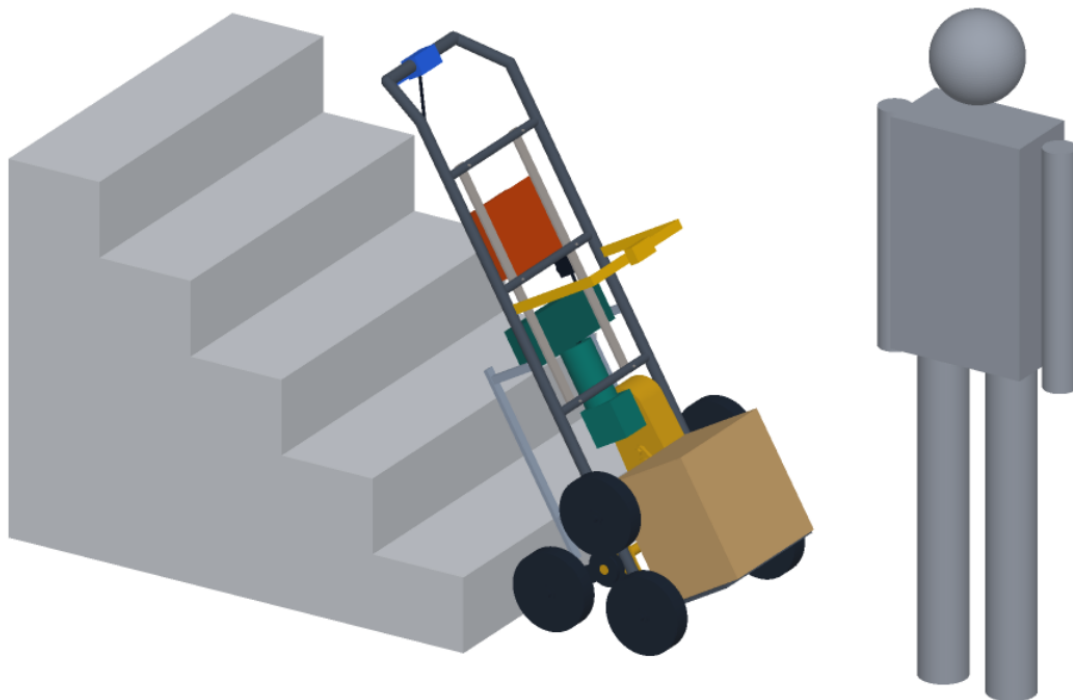
StepClimber design precis

StepClimber is a steel hand truck whose two wheels are replaced by a pair of powered tri-star clusters on one shaft. A 24 V worm gearmotor with a built-in brake turns the clusters, through a two-stage chain drive, one third of a turn per step, lifting 60 kg of parcels up a residential stair while the courier walks ahead and steadies the handle. An IMU on the frame watches the tilt angle, shapes the motor speed so the courier can hold the load near its balance point, and stops the climb if the angle drifts. This version carries the cluster and drive rework and the tighter tilt window Amish decided on 2026-09-25 (SCM-DDR-002), in which 200 mm wheels on 150 mm arms keep every steel part clear of stair nosings, and the constructable design of SCM-DDR-003 (2026-10-01), in which every part is fixed to its neighbours: bearings on axle plates welded inside the rails, a closed chain case, a countershaft in two bearings and the electronics on uprights. The calculations (SCM-CAL-001 v0.5) give about 1,215 loaded steps per charge from a 256 Wh LiFePO4 pack and a 34.2 kg truck. **Three requirements that were not met on paper are met after Amish's decisions of 2026-10-02** (SCM-DEC-001): R5 is set to 35 kg for the first prototype (34.2 kg), R3 to 16 steps/min (the 250 W motor climbs at 16.3), and the tilt window to plus or minus 3 degrees for the first loaded trials, which keeps the grip force at 100 N or less (R6). Value-engineering target: USD 650. Estimated cost of the constructable design: USD 776 (USD 126 over the target). The prototype build plan is SCM-BLD-001 ([docs/05-build-plan.md](#)).

StepClimber

github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/stepclimber

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION



Seen from the front right and above, 24 deg elevation. Grey figure: 1.75 m person for scale

Figure 1. StepClimber tilted back for climbing at the foot of a residential stair (196 mm risers, 254 mm treads), with a parcel carton on the toe plate and a 1.75 m person for scale. Rendered from the TRL 3 model with the 2026-09-25 rework (cad/src/model.py). The stair and carton are context only.

■ How it works

- 1. Load.** The courier stacks parcels on the toe plate against the frame and tightens the ratchet strap. On the flat the truck rolls on two wheels of each cluster like any hand truck; the gearmotor holds the clusters still and each wheel spins freely on its own axle.
- 2. Set.** At the foot of the stair the courier backs the truck up to the first riser, tilts it back to the balance point (about 30 degrees from vertical for a typical load), squeezes the dead-man grip and presses "up". The controller stores the current frame angle as the set angle.
- 3. Climb.** The gearmotor turns the cluster shaft through a 7:1 two-stage chain drive in a closed chain case (a countershaft in the case carries the first-stage driven sprocket and the small final-stage sprocket). The lower rear wheel of each cluster presses against the riser and becomes the pivot; the cluster turns about it until the top wheel lands on the tread above, then turns about the landed wheel for the rest of the third of a turn. Each one-third turn lifts the truck one step, and the courier rolls it back on the landed wheel to the next riser (about 84 mm on the design stair). The courier walks up backwards one step ahead, holding the handle.
- 4. Hold the angle.** The frame pitches as the clusters roll over each nosing. The IMU reads the frame angle at 100 Hz or faster. The controller slows the motor near the end of each third of a turn so the landing wheel does not thump, and slows further if the angle moves away from the set angle so the courier can correct it. If the angle leaves a window of plus or minus 3 degrees (for the first loaded trials, SCM-DEC-001 item 4; widened toward plus or minus 6 degrees only once grip force is measured), or the range 15 to 45 degrees back from vertical, the motor stops and the spring-applied brake holds, and a light bar and buzzer on the handle tell the courier which way to move the handle.
- 5. Descend.** "Down" drives the clusters backwards at the same controlled speed. The worm drive is self-locking, so the load cannot run away down the stair; the motor drives the descent rather than a brake restraining it.
- 6. Stop.** Releasing the grip, a fault, a flat battery or a pulled pack all leave the truck held on the step by the self-locking worm and the motor's spring-applied brake.

Tilt control keeps the operator in the loop. The truck has only the clusters on the stair and the courier's hands on the handle, so it cannot hold its own angle; the IMU makes the climb slow down and stop in a way that helps the courier hold it. Amish decided this reading on 2026-09-25, and the pitch now says "a tilt sensor that helps the courier hold the load angle steady" (SCM-DDR-001 item 1).

StepClimber: energy for one loaded step up, J per step (calculated: 94 kg, 196 mm riser)

github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/stepclimber

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

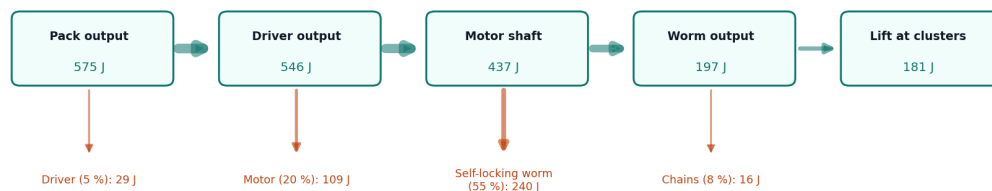


Figure 2. Energy for one loaded step up, in joules per step, from the pack to the lift at the clusters. Design load case of 94 kg total on a 196 mm riser. Values from SCM-CAL-001 v0.5 (calculated, not measured).

■ Main components

Numbers match the exploded view (Figure 3) and `bom/bom.csv`.

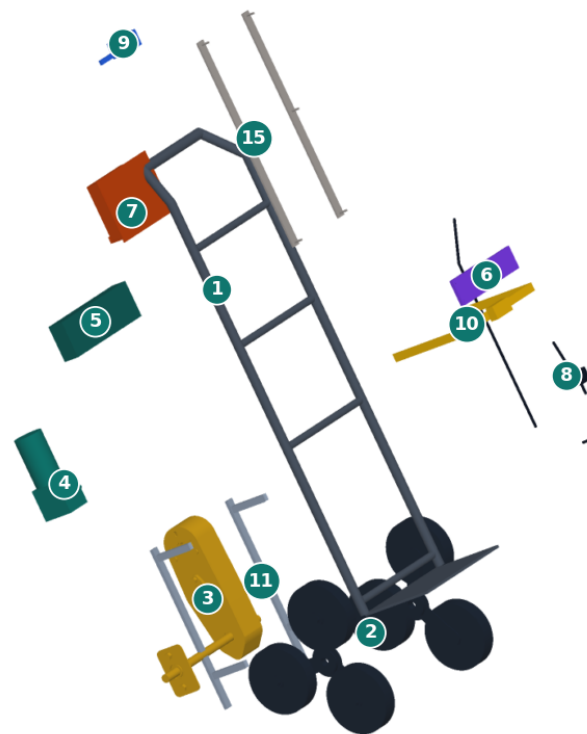
Table 1. Main components.

#	Component	Proposed choice	Notes
1	Hand truck frame	Steel loop-handle hand truck, 28 mm rails 400 mm apart, grip 1,260 mm from the shaft, 380 x 240 mm toe plate; lowest cross bar moved below the shaft line; axle plates, skid standoffs and component uprights added (BOM lines 14 to 16)	Commercial frame modified; about 8 kg
2	Tri-star wheel clusters (pair)	Laser-cut steel spiders, 150 mm hub-to-wheel arms, weld-on taper-lock hubs, 20 mm stub axles, three 200 mm solid rubber wheels on sealed bearings each	Wheel spacing about 260 mm; non-marking tread; about 6.3 kg
3	Cluster shaft and two-stage chain drive	25 mm keyed shaft in two flange bearings on the axle plates; 20 mm countershaft in two flange bearings, 144 mm up the frame; first stage 06B 10T to 35T, final stage 08B 10T to 20T (7:1 overall); all in a closed chain case (line 14)	Case inside the nosing envelope (R15 met)
4	Worm gearmotor with brake	24 V brushed, about 250 W, worm gearbox about 40 rpm output and 30 N·m rated, spring-applied electromagnetic brake (wheelchair type)	Self-locking worm plus brake: two independent holds
5	Motor driver	24 V, 30 A brushed H-bridge with current sensing and a brake output	Current limit caps cluster torque
6	Controller with IMU	Small microcontroller, 6-axis IMU, light bar and buzzer, in a sealed box with item 5, on the component uprights	Tilt window, speed shaping, hold-to-run logic
7	Battery pack	24 V LiFePO ₄ , 8S, 10 Ah (256 Wh), BMS, quick-release cradle	About 2.6 kg
8	Main switch, fuse and harness	Key switch, 40 A fuse near the pack, keyed connectors	
9	Handle controls	Dead-man grip lever, up and down thumb switch, status light bar	Works with gloves
10	Load strap	Ratchet strap across the load, fixed to the frame	Stops parcels sliding off when pitching
11	Nosing guard skids	UHMW polyethylene strips on welded standoffs behind the rails, 100 mm behind the shaft line	Protect stairs if the frame touches a nosing
12	Charger	29.2 V, 3 A LiFePO ₄ charger	No exploded-view callout
13	Enclosure and hardware	Sealed box, fasteners, cable ties	No exploded-view callout
14 to 17	Parts added to make the design buildable	Axle plates and chain case, component uprights, frame modification steel, fixings (SCM-DDR-003)	Uprights are callout 15; the case is part of callout 3

StepClimber: exploded viewgithub.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/stepclimber

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Steel hand truck frame and toe plate
- 2 Tri-star wheel clusters (pair)
- 3 Cluster shaft, bearings and chain drive
- 4 Worm gearmotor with brake, 24 V
- 5 Motor driver, 24 V 30 A
- 6 Controller with IMU tilt sensor
- 7 24 V LiFePO4 pack, 10 Ah
- 8 Main switch, fuse and harness
- 9 Handle with dead-man grip
- 10 Load strap with ratchet
- 11 Nosing guard skids
- 15 Component uprights



Seen from the front right and above, 24 deg elevation; numbers match bom/bom.csv

Figure 3. Exploded view with numbered callouts matching the BOM.

■ Key numbers

All values are from SCM-CAL-001 v0.5, printed by `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`. They are paper calculations, not measurements. The design load case is a 60 kg payload on a 34.2 kg truck (94.2 kg total) on a stair with 196 mm risers and 254 mm treads. The clusters are assumed to carry the whole weight while lifting, which is conservative.

Cluster geometry and nosing clearance

A tri-star cluster climbs by pivoting about the wheel pressed against the riser. With a wheel-center spacing d and riser h , the landing wheel's center comes down $\sqrt{d^2 - h^2}$ from the pivot's center, and its contact point lands that distance less the 100 mm wheel radius past the riser face.

Table 2. Cluster geometry.

Quantity	Value	Basis
Arm length (hub to wheel center)	150 mm (was 135 mm)	Decided 2026-09-25, SCM-DDR-002
Wheel diameter	200 mm (was 150 mm)	Decided 2026-09-25, SCM-DDR-002
Wheel-center spacing d	259.8 mm	150 mm x $\sqrt{3}$
Hub height on the flat	175.0 mm	100 mm wheel radius + 150 mm x $\sin 30^\circ$
Cluster overall diameter	500 mm	2 x (150 + 100) mm
Landing past a square nosing, 196 mm riser	70.5 mm	$\sqrt{259.8^2 \text{ minus } 196^2}$ minus 100
Landing past a square nosing, 200 mm riser	65.8 mm	
Largest riser with 30 mm of landing	225 mm	R2 range of 100 to 200 mm covered
Longest tread needed (100 mm riser)	240 mm	R2 treads of 250 mm or more covered
Closest approach of a nosing to the shaft line	87.1 mm (square nosing), 64.2 mm (32 mm overhang)	Section 3 of SCM-CAL-001
Largest radius allowed on the shaft line	77 mm (square), 54.2 mm (32 mm overhang)	Less a 10 mm margin
Chain case radius on the shaft line	53.9 mm	R15 met, sized to the limit
Countershaft guard clearance to the nearest nosing	80 mm	R15 met
Every frame-fixed outline near the shaft to the nearest nosing	10.3 mm or more	R15 met (10 mm wanted)
Nosing overhang the spider arms clear	32 mm, 19.5 mm to spare at worst	R2 met

The nosing passes through the gap between the two lower arms, close to the shaft, as the swinging wheel lands. On the v0.1 cluster the 60-tooth sprocket and its guard struck every nosing. The larger wheels hold the pivot farther from the riser and higher, which moves the hub away from the nosing, and the small 08B final sprocket fits in the space left. The chain case, axle plates and bearings of the constructable design all stay inside that space.

Drive, speed and torque

Assumptions: 16 steps per minute, so one third of a turn every 3.75 s (5.33 rpm, 0.559 rad/s at the shaft); drive efficiencies as in SCM-REQ-001.

Table 3. Drive.

Quantity	Value	Basis	Requirement
Lift work per step	181 J	94.2 kg x 9.81 m/s ² x 0.196 m	
Mean shaft torque	86 N·m	181 J / 2.09 rad	
Peak shaft torque	139 N·m static, 181 N·m with a 1.3 factor	Full load on the 150 mm arm, plus the grip force	
Peak shaft power	101 W	181 N·m x 0.559 rad/s	
Peak motor output	244 W	101 W / (0.95 x 0.97 chain stages x 0.45 worm)	2 % under a 250 W motor at 16 steps/min; the motor gives at most 16.4 steps/min, so R3 (16 steps/min for the first prototype, set 2026-10-02) is met (17 steps/min would need 260 W)
Gearmotor output	28.1 N·m at 37 rpm	181 N·m / (7 x 0.95 x 0.97)	Inside a 30 N·m rating
Final stage (08B, 10T to 20T, 38 links) chain pull	4,465 N	Safety factor 4.0	
First stage (06B, 10T to 35T, 54 links) chain pull	1,759 N	Safety factor 5.1	

R3 was revised to 17 steps per minute on 2026-09-25 to keep the 250 W wheelchair motor; the heavier constructable truck needs slightly more than that motor gives, so Amish set R3 to 16 steps per minute for the first prototype on 2026-10-02 (SCM-DEC-001, item 3). The controller sets the speed, so a faster motor can follow later.

Energy and endurance

Table 4. Energy.

Quantity	Value	Basis	Requirement
Pack energy per loaded step up	575 J (0.16 Wh)	181 J / (0.95 x 0.80 x 0.45 x 0.95 x 0.97)	
Pack energy per loaded step down	46 J	Driving a self-locking worm while the load assists takes 21 % of the lift work, plus motor and driver losses	
Usable pack energy	829 kJ	256 Wh x 90 %	
Loaded steps per charge, up and down	1,215	829 kJ / (621 J x 1.1 for standby and starts)	R4 met
Typical day	25 drops of three floors (48 steps) each		
Charge time	3.5 h	256 Wh / (87.6 W x 0.9) plus a 0.3 h constant-voltage tail	R13 met

The self-locking worm wastes more than half the drive energy (Figure 2). It is kept because it holds the load without power (SCM-DDR-001 item 5). Its back-drive efficiency is -0.22, so it cannot be driven backwards by a static load; the 2 N·m motor brake alone would hold the load with a 7.5-times margin.

Balance, handle force and rolling

During a step the support point moves under the hub: the hub goes from 29 mm on the stair side of the support wheel to 150 mm beyond it. With the frame angle held, the center of mass swings plus or minus 89 mm about the support point even at the best set angle, and a further 26 mm at the edge of the plus or minus 3 degree window.

Table 5. Handle force.

Quantity	Value	Requirement
Grip force at the set angle, worst point of a step	76 N	
Grip force at a plus or minus 3 degree window edge	99 N	R6 met (121 N at a plus or minus 6 degree edge)
Widest window that keeps the grip force at 100 N	Plus or minus 3.1 degrees	R6 met with the plus or minus 3 degree window set for the first loaded trials (SCM-DEC-001, item 4)
Push force on the flat	28 N	R10 met

The longer arm that fixes the nosing clearance also widens the swing of the load (plus or minus 71 mm on the v0.1 cluster), so the plus or minus 6 degree window decided on 2026-09-25 does not bring the grip force under 100 N; the plus or minus 3 degree window set on 2026-10-02 for the first loaded trials does.

Structure

At the 181 N·m peak and a 3 g dropped-step load, the safety factors on yield are 2.5 for the keyed 25 mm shaft in 4140 quenched and tempered steel (it was 1.4 in 1018 before Amish decided on 2026-10-02 to change the material; its bearings sit inside the frame, 93 mm from the wheel plane), 1.5 for the 6 mm spider arms and 3.2 for the 28 mm frame rails (R1 met statically). The shaft has a fatigue safety factor of 1.8 on paper; fatigue of the welded frame is not assessed.

Mass and size

Table 6. Mass and size.

Item	Value
Frame 8.0, clusters 5.5 and stub axles 0.8, shafts, bearings, sprockets and chains 5.5, gearmotor 4.5, electronics 0.8, pack 2.6, harness 0.5, handle controls 0.6, strap 0.4, skids 0.4, hardware 0.5, axle plates and chain case 2.5, uprights 0.6, skid standoffs 0.5, added fixings 0.5 kg	34.2 kg (R5 met against the 35 kg set for the first prototype on 2026-10-02; was 27 kg)
Overall width at the wheel faces; over the wheel end screws	569 mm; 588 mm (R11 met)
Upright height, fixed handle	1,451 mm (R11 met at 1,500 mm)
Folded height with a hinge 950 mm above the shaft (Option C study)	1,139 mm; not adopted

Cost

Value-engineering target: USD 650. Estimated cost of the constructable design: USD 788 including the charger (USD 138 over the target). See [bom/bom.csv](#) and the value-engineering section of the design decisions register ([docs/06-design-decisions.md](#)).

■ Key design choices

Items marked **decided** were decided by Amish on 2026-09-25 (SCM-DDR-001 and SCM-DDR-002), going with the recommendation.

- **Tri-star clusters rather than a stepping arm or tracks (decided).** Tri-stars are simple, roll on the flat without extra parts and are well understood. Stepping-arm climbers carry more and handle more stair shapes, and tracks are smoothest, but both are harder to build in a garage and cost more ([XSTO overview](#)). The cost of the tri-star is the thump at each nosing, a fixed stair range and, as SCM-CAL-001 shows, very little room near the shaft.
- **Operator-in-the-loop tilt control (decided).** Speed shaping, a tilt window, stop and alert, with no actuated load platform. The pitch was reworded to match.
- **Self-locking worm plus spring-applied brake (decided).** Two independent holds on a stair, at the cost of more than half the drive energy.
- **24 V LiFePO4, not the 48 V SwapCell pack (decided).** The drive needs about 240 W peak and 230 Wh per shift; LiFePO4 is the more forgiving chemistry for a pack that is dropped in and out of vans. SwapCell would add a CAN host adapter and cost more than half the budget. The SwapCell interface v0.3 items do not apply.
- **Fixed handle for the first prototype (decided).** R11 is relaxed to 1,500 mm; the 1,451 mm truck meets it. A folding hinge (Option C) was studied and not adopted.
- **Rated stair load of 60 kg (decided).** Higher than manual tri-star trucks (about 35 kg on stairs) and lower than stepping climbers (110 to 170 kg).
- **Operator above, truck below (decided).** The courier always stands uphill of the truck, going up (pulling) and going down (lowering). This goes on the labels and in the user guide.
- **Cluster and drive rework for R2 and R15 (decided).** 150 mm arms, 200 mm wheels and a two-stage chain drive with an O8B 20-tooth final sprocket. It fixes both stair-contact failures at the cost of about 2 kg, \$53 and a slower climb.
- **Revised targets after the rework (decided).** R3 17 steps/min on the present 250 W motor, R5 27 kg and R12 \$650, set from the priced parts. For the first prototype Amish set R3 to 16 steps/min and R5 to 35 kg on 2026-10-02 (SCM-DEC-001, items 2 and 3).
- **Tilt window (decided).** Tightened from 8 to 6 degrees on 2026-09-25, which did not by itself meet R6 on the larger cluster; set to plus or minus 3 degrees for the first loaded trials on 2026-10-02.
- **Grip force after the rework (R6) (decided 2026-10-02).** R6 stays at 100 N; the tilt window is tightened to plus or minus 3 degrees for the first loaded trials, and widened toward plus or minus 6 degrees only when grip force is measured at 100 N or less, or operators are shown to handle the measured force safely (SCM-DEC-001, item 4).
- **Design for construction (SCM-DDR-003) (decided 2026-10-02).** Made on 2026-10-01 under Amish's 2026-09-30 instruction to make the design physically buildable, and accepted on 2026-10-02 with one exception: the 25 mm cluster shaft is quenched and tempered alloy steel such as 4140 instead of 1018. Bearings on axle plates welded inside the rails, a closed chain case carrying the countershaft and gearmotor, chain centres for whole chains, weld-on hubs and stub axles, component uprights, skid standoffs and a relocated lowest cross bar.

■ Safety

Safety: StepClimber moves an 86 kg mass on a stair with a person directly uphill of it, has a pinch-prone chain and rotating clusters, and carries a 256 Wh lithium iron phosphate pack. A fall of the loaded truck down a stair could crush or seriously injure the operator or anyone below. Treat every item here as a hazard to design out before any loaded climb.

- **Cluster shaft.** The 25 mm shaft carries the whole load at a dropped step; its 1.4 factor on 1018 steel led to a choice of quenched and tempered alloy steel such as 4140 (SCM-DEC-001, item 1), which gives 2.5 at a 3 g dropped step and a fatigue factor of 1.8 on paper (SCM-CAL-001 v0.5, section 8). The tensile strength is to be confirmed from the mill certificate, and a fatigue test at TRL 4 should come before any loaded stair trial.
- **Runaway and tip-over on the stair.** The main hazard. Two independent holds (self-locking worm and spring-applied brake), hold-to-run control, the tilt window and a rated load label are all required. Nobody may stand downhill of the truck on the stair. The frame must not be able to pass over center toward the operator if the grip is released: the tilt limits of 15 and 45 degrees protect against this only if the brake holds, which is unverified.
- **Operator falls.** The courier walks backwards up the stair. Speed is limited to about 16 steps per minute and stops the moment the grip opens. The handle should leave one hand free for a stair rail where possible; this is an open question.
- **Pinch and entanglement.** The clusters rotate with up to about 182 N·m and the chain runs near the operator's feet. The chains and sprockets are enclosed in a closed chain case; the cluster spiders have no open gaps large enough for fingers when the truck is at rest; clothing and straps must be kept clear.
- **Lithium iron phosphate pack.** LiFePO₄ is less prone to thermal runaway than other lithium-ion chemistries but can still vent and burn if crushed, shorted or overcharged. Use a pack with a BMS and cell-level protection, fuse the output (item 8), charge on a non-combustible surface away from sleeping areas, and never charge a damaged or wet pack. Charging below 0 °C must be blocked by the BMS.
- **Stair and building damage, and nosing strike.** Rubber wheels and skids protect nosings. After the rework no steel part reaches a nosing on paper, but the chain case is sized to the limit of its envelope on the shaft line, so a bent case or a stair outside the R2 range could still be struck. A strike could jerk the frame toward the courier or stall the climb with the load half-lifted, so the case must be kept straight and the stair range respected.
- **Loads and grip force.** Unsecured parcels can slide as the frame pitches. The strap is mandatory. Loads with a high center of mass (tall boxes) shift the balance angle and raise the handle force, which reaches 121 N at a plus or minus 6 degree window edge on the design load; the window is therefore plus or minus 3 degrees for the first loaded trials.

■ Open questions

Open decisions are indexed in the design decisions register (<docs/06-design-decisions.md>).

- R6, R5 and R3: decided by Amish on 2026-10-02 (SCM-DEC-001, items 2 to 4). Measure grip force at TRL 4 before widening the tilt window.
- Survey riser, tread and nosing sizes in walk-up buildings in the first target city (R2).
- Confirm that the worm stays self-locking under vibration and measure the brake's holding torque (R8); these need hardware and wait for TRL 4, which is on hold.
- Assess fatigue of the keyed shaft and the welded frame.

- First user group and partner: decided by Amish on 2026-10-02 (SCM-DEC-001, items 6 and 7): parcel couriers serving walk-up apartment buildings first, then gig couriers; a regional parcel or last-mile delivery company for a small supervised pilot, chosen from the interviews.

Concept media: [blueprint sheet](#), [interactive 3D model](#). General arrangement: [SCM-DWG-001 Rev P5](#). Prototype build plan: [SCM-BLD-001](#).